

A PRINTABLE FAMILY PLANNER

Ready for a Dog?

A gentle 4-week kit to decide together, practice the routine with your little one, and welcome a dog into a home that already has a cat.

8 PAGES • PRINT AT HOME • AGES 3+ WITH A GROWN-UP

START HERE

How to use this kit

Your child asks for a dog every day. This kit turns that wish into a calm family project: four short weeks, one page at a time. By the end you will know if now is the right time, and your child will have practised real care.

1. **Week 1 — Talk & check**
   Go through the Family Readiness Checklist together after dinner. Be honest; a "not yet" is a good answer too.
2. **Week 1 — Do the money**
   Fill in the Monthly Dog Budget with real local prices. Most families are surprised by the "hidden" lines.
3. **Weeks 1-4 — Little Helper Chart**
   Your child practises picture-based jobs with the cat (or a plush dog). One sticker or colored dot per job.
4. **Weeks 1-4 — 30-Day Practice Challenge**
   A tiny daily task to build the habit. Missed days are fine; just continue the next day.
5. **When you decide yes — Cat & Dog Plan**
   A week-by-week introduction plan that keeps your cat safe and relaxed.
6. **Finish — Our Dog Promise**
   Everyone signs, your child draws the dog they dream of. Pin it to the fridge.

Printing tips

US Letter or A4, "fit to page". Print the chart and challenge pages twice if you have two children. Card stock makes the promise page last longer.

A note for parents

This is a planning aid, not veterinary or legal advice. Ask your vet and local shelter about breeds, costs and rules where you live.

WEEK 1 · TALK & CHECK

Family Readiness Checklist

Tick what is already true. Every open box is something to plan for, not a reason to feel bad.

Our home

- [ ] Our lease / building allows dogs
- [ ] Safe outdoor spot or a park nearby
- [ ] A quiet corner for a dog bed
- [ ] Cat has high places & a dog-free room
- [ ] Toys and food can be kept off the floor

Our time

- [ ] 2–3 walks a day fit our schedule
- [ ] Someone is home or a walker is possible
- [ ] We can do weekly training for 3 months
- [ ] Holiday plan: family, sitter or boarding
- [ ] The adults agree who does mornings

Our money

- [ ] Monthly budget filled in (next page)
- [ ] Emergency vet savings or insurance
- [ ] Start-up costs saved (bed, crate, vet)

Our family

- [ ] No one in the home has a dog allergy
- [ ] Our child can follow 2 simple dog rules
- [ ] We talked about which size suits us

Our decision today

- [ ] Yes, let's prepare
- [ ] Not yet — check again on _____

WEEK 1 · DO THE MONEY

Monthly Dog Budget

Write your local prices. Add the start-up costs once, then the monthly lines. Ask your vet for a typical yearly cost in your area.

START-UP (ONE TIME)	ESTIMATE	ACTUAL
Adoption / breeder fee		
First vet visit, vaccines, microchip		
Crate, bed, bowls, leash, harness		
Baby gate (keeps the cat's space safe)		
Puppy / obedience class		
Start-up total		

EVERY MONTH	ESTIMATE	ACTUAL
Food & treats		
Insurance or vet savings		
Flea, tick & worm prevention		
Grooming		
Dog walker / daycare		
Toys, poop bags, extras		
Monthly total		

WE CAN COMFORTABLY SPEND PER MONTH

DIFFERENCE (COMFORTABLE – MONTHLY TOTAL)

WEEKS 1-4 · FOR LITTLE HANDS

Little Helper Chart

Practise with your cat or a plush dog. Your child adds a sticker or a colored dot for every job done. Pictures help pre-readers.

JOB	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Fill the food bowl							
Fresh water							
Gentle brushing							
Play for 10 minutes							
Tidy toys away							
Quiet time: let pet rest							

WEEK OF

OUR REWARD WHEN THE CHART IS FULL

WEEKS 1-4 · ONE TINY TASK A DAY

30-Day Practice Challenge

Read the task together, do it, color the circle. Grown-ups help with the reading; kids do the doing.

DAY 1 Draw your dream dog	DAY 2 Feed the cat with a grown-up	DAY 3 Learn: let a sleeping pet sleep	DAY 4 Walk the plush dog around the block	DAY 5 Fill the water bowl alone
DAY 6 Pick 3 dog names	DAY 7 Visit a dog-friendly park	DAY 8 Learn: ask before you pet	DAY 9 Brush the cat gently	DAY 10 Tidy toys off the floor
DAY 11 Read a dog picture book	DAY 12 Play "sit & wait" with family	DAY 13 Feed the cat on time, morning	DAY 14 Say hi to a friend's calm dog	DAY 15 Halfway! Show a grown-up your chart
DAY 16 Learn: dogs need quiet corners	DAY 17 Practice a rainy-day walk	DAY 18 Make a "dog bed" spot plan	DAY 19 Play 10 min with the cat	DAY 20 Learn: no hugging a dog's neck
DAY 21 Help sort groceries for pets	DAY 22 Draw where the cat can hide	DAY 23 Early-morning "walk" at 7:00	DAY 24 Clean the food bowl together	DAY 25 Learn 3 dog body-language signs
DAY 26 Visit a pet shop, just look	DAY 27 Feed the cat on time, evening	DAY 28 Tell the family a dog rule	DAY 29 Look at the budget together	DAY 30 Sign Our Dog Promise!

WHEN YOU DECIDE YES

Cat & Dog Introduction Plan

Go slowly. Move to the next step only when both pets are relaxed. Many introductions take two to four weeks.

BEFORE **Prep**	Set up a dog-free room for the cat (food, water, litter, bed). Add shelves or a cat tree. Fit a baby gate. Ask the shelter if the dog has lived with cats.
DAYS 1-3 **Smell**	Keep them apart. Swap a blanket between rooms so they learn each other's scent. Feed both near the closed door.
DAYS 4-7 **See**	Short look-only sessions through the baby gate, dog on a leash, treats for calm behaviour. Stop before anyone gets stressed.
WEEK 2 **Share**	Leashed dog in the same room, cat free to leave and climb high. Five minutes, twice a day. Lots of praise.
WEEK 3+ **Live**	Supervised time together. The cat's room stays dog-free for good. Never leave them alone together until you are sure.

Our notes & progress

FINISH · PIN IT TO THE FRIDGE

Our Dog Promise

- [ ] We will feed and walk our dog every day, even when it rains.
- [ ] We will keep the cat's safe room dog-free.
- [ ] We will ask before we pet, and let a sleeping dog sleep.
- [ ] We will go to training together.
- [ ] We will take care of our dog for its whole life.

DRAW OUR DOG HERE

OUR DOG'S NAME

DATE

GROWN-UP

GROWN-UP

LITTLE HELPER

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